DESIGN METHODS AS MEANS FOR CHALLENGING ORGANIZATIONAL PRACTICES – CASE: RECRUITING

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ABSTRACT

Many of the organizational systems and work practices, e.g. recruiting processes, especially in the public sector have remained relatively unchanged during the last decades. In this paper we argue for, the potential of applying typical design competences such as empathic and visual methods, as tools to support 'out of the box' -thinking and spirit of an instant experimentation in organizational practices. This argument is based on a case study that took place in the context of recruiting. The gained experiences suggest that developing a recruiting event that simulates realistic working tasks, candidates' expectations, interests, skills, character and suitability can be revealed more profoundly than through traditional interviewing methods.

Keywords: organizational practices, design methods, design thinking, recruiting practices

INTRODUCTION

Employees are one of the company's most important resources. Carbonara (1996) claims that without hiring great people it is impossible to build a great company. He is pointing out the challenge of recognizing the great future employees when you see them. His discussion is based on three companies whose recruiting goals include finding certain type of energy and self-confidence rather than particular skills and experiences. Therefore recruiting occasions might be the most important investments to the company's future, or at least they could be. Is the traditional recruiting process that is mainly based on traditional written applications and interview-based processes an optimal solution? Whether or not, it is constantly repeated similarly in most of the companies without any practical relation to the vacancy or the type of the organization. How about challenging the recruiting practices by applying design methods in the recruiting to find the most suitable candidate?

Many of the internal systems and work practices in organizations have remained relatively unchanged during the last decades, although the development and change in the surrounding society has been strong (e.g. Thackara 2005, Burns et al. 2006). People in organizations have become accustomed to some of these traditional patterns, that they are not questioned. To give some examples, every day practices such as personal development discussions, rewarding systems, communication practices, routines for arranging meetings as well as the already mentioned recruiting process, are factors that build the way the organization functions and influence the organizational culture.

According to Buchanan (2008) design can be used within organizations beyond its earlier tradition of giving form to objects. Design can be applied to: "the design of organizations, environments, and systems that serve the diverse purposes of human beings". (Buchanan 2008, 9.) Therefore challenging the way an organization functions on a practical level, can bring forth new kind of commitment and motivation among workers. The topic is also closely related to wellbeing at work. When employees feel important and acknowledged, they feel more likely as part of the organization. At the same time the individual employee's skills and potential can be better utilized, which influences positively on the general atmosphere, attitude and spirit (e.g. Buchanan & Huczynski 2004, 2-9). These factors

influence the organization's ability to be effective, functional and creative, and in other words they can establish a framework for innovation. Thus, it would be beneficial from both the candidates' and the organizations' point of view to motivate the candidates already during the recruiting process.

BACKGROUND FRAMEWORKS

Exploring the possibility to re-think and re-design the existing manners requires a new mindset, tools and approaches. Thus the background for our case study is based on design thinking literature and previous work done in the field of design research, mainly in the area of empathic, generative and participatory methods. Based on this framework we suggest that design methods and practices can be used to re-design intangible concepts as well as create tangible tools to support communication and turn them into practices as part of management processes.

DESIGN THINKING

Schön (1983) in his "Reflective practitioner" gave background for the concept of design thinking and in academic world the concept has been alive since that (e.g. Johansson & Woodilla 2010). However, during the last few years the discussion about design thinking has gained a lot of attention in business literature. Authors like Roger Martin (2007), Tim Brown (2008) and Thomas Lockwood (2010) have been in the vanguard of this multidisciplinary discussion. These authors describe the concept of design thinking "as a specific way of thinking and using design methods by non-designers" (Johansson & Woodilla 2010, 3).

According e.g. Lockwood (2010) design thinking emphasizes collaboration between different disciplines, learning by doing mentality, visualizations and rapid prototyping. In addition some authors (e.g. Brown 2008) claim that design thinking is also about the way one sees the world. In design thinker's mind despite the challenge, the potential new solution is better than the existing alternatives. Design thinking is also about experimental and explorative mind-set. This includes the willingness to explore possibilities and take controlled risks. (Brown 2008) Design thinking can be applied to solve wicked problems and to enhance innovation processes particularly in its front-end activities (e.g. Brown 2008; Cooper et al. 2009; Drew 2009; Lockwood 2010). According the Dunne & Martin (2007) design thinking can help managers in decision-making. "Designerly way" of doing things gives even value to the process of formulating the company strategy or business plan (Holloway 2009; Ward et al. 2009).

Based on our experimentation we want to shift the focus of applying designerly approach from companies´ front-end-activities to organizational development, such as enhancing management processes (see Buchanan 2008).

DESIGNERLY APPROACH

In line with earlier mentioned characteristics of design thinking, traditional design competences, such as empathic, generative and participatory methods, visual thinking and communication, as well as rapid prototyping techniques and tangible sketching, are tools to apply with 'out of the box'-thinking and spirit of an instant experimentation into the organization and challenge the traditional manners.

In this paper we define "designerly approach" as a set of exploratory, generative, empathic and participatory methods, focusing on understanding people, in this case the candidates, "beneath the surface", beyond what they only say and tell. This definition follows Liz Sanders' well established framework called Say-Do-Make (Sanders and Dandavate 1999). Accordign to Sandrers, we can understand peoples needs and dreams more profoundly and thereby establish empathy by exploring what people say, what people do and what people make, simultaneously.

In Sanders' model "say" refers to what people say and tell, "do" refers to seeing and observing what people do and use, and "make" refers to what people know, feel and dream. The traditional research methods such as interviews, focus groups or questionnaires concentrate only on what people say and think. With these methods the behavioral data,

meaning the observable "do" part and the "make" part (the use of mostly non-verbal, constructive means to describe and represent experiences e.g. peoples tacit and latent thoughts, feelings or dreams) cannot be captured. (Sanders 2002; Koskinen et al. 2003, 59-60)

Therefore to encourage people to explore and access these features, different kinds of generative techniques and triggering materials are needed. Generative toolkits (e.g. make-tools, Sanders 2000) contain typically visual and tangible materials, such as building blocks and collage making materials, which trigger people to map, visualize and express their ideas and thoughts as well as explore and reflect on their tacit and latent dreams and needs.

Empathic methods are interpretative by nature and it is in these generative and participatory encounters with the users, researchers and other stakeholders, when empathic understanding can occur. There are several methods to organize and facilitate such encounters e.g. contextmapping (Sleeswijk Visser et al. 2005) as well as co-design and design games sessions (Vaajakallio et al. 2010; Sanders 2000; Buur et. al 2008; Brandt 2006).

Characteristics of empathic methods are that they are often playful and inspiring and thus support designerly thinking. They are easy to adapt in real life situations, as they are low-tech and cheap to put into practice (Koskinen et al. 2003, 8). In the context of this case study, empathic methods were also used to encourage candidates to challenge the traditional behavioral patterns of a recruiting event as well as act more informally and be more open-minded, which is closely related to previous work done in the area of design explorations within public organizations e.g. Mattelmäki et al. (2009).

MAIN GOALS OF THE CASE STUDY

Our main argument for challenging the traditional interviewing based recruiting practices was to bring content related practical dimension to the recruiting process. Usually, when applicants are presenting themselves in a job interview they describe their character and skills as they would like to see themselves according to their own opinion and values. Whether the verbal description meets reality is uncertain. Even the applicants themselves may have an unrealistic picture about their character, skills and potential.

The main reason to arrange a recruiting session differently was to get a novel understanding of the candidate's realistic performance in the position he is applying for. Another matter was to assure that the candidates were motivated and their character would fit to the profile defined for the position. In our case study a particular type of attitude was required for the specific vacancies, that could not be assured without rather "seeing and feeling" it.

The intention of the study was not to deliver a new and perfect practice that would be rooted directly in to the organization within the next decades, but rather to create the first prototype of new recruiting practices that would offer a better opportunity to get deeper understanding of future employee candidates' qualities. In addition this experiment was part of a bigger research effort on the applications of designerly methods in organizations.

THE CASE STUDY: RECRUITING WORKSHOP AS A PROTOTYPE OF NEW MANAGEMENT PRACTICES

In our case study the designerly approach was applied to the context of public sector to challenge the traditional way of organizing recruiting process. The starting context of the experiment was a creation of a new consultancy unit for a public sector organization that was about to be founded. In the new unit a leader and a dynamic team of four members were required to be recruited to run it. The new unit was expected to be operating innovatively and customer approach was defined as a core fundamental. As fundamental requirements all the future employees, particularly the director, should possess an innovative way of thinking and open-minded attitude, be able to adapt new conditions easily and also be able to develop further the concept defined for the new consultancy unit. A realistic work task simulation as a part of recruiting practices was created to provide an opportunity to test how applicants can handle situations of

uncomfortable zones. Suitable working attitude and capability to think innovatively were also important qualities to be revealed in the new recruiting application.

DEVELOPING THE RECRUITING WORKSHOP CONCEPT

The main goal of creating the recruiting workshop was to find the best future employees and obviate the need of probationary period in finding out if the candidate would be capable in performing well in real working tasks. Written applications and candidate's oral self-descriptions versus the interviewer's interpretation of them, may not meet reality. The first prototype in challenging this assumption was a new recruiting practice in the form of a hands-on workshop event including visual and tangible tools to support and enhance the communication.

PROCESS & BACKGROUND

The recruiting planning, investigation and test observation was done by a group of design researchers who were involved in the operational planning of the new organization. As being created with the prototyping-driven mentality in mind, the recruiting event was the first prototype of possible practices for a renewed recruiting process accentuating candidate's holistic performance in accomplishing possible future working tasks. It was not meant to be the final version of an additional new layer of recruiting practices but rather a combination of interviews and hands-on performing.

After initial review and successful traditional work interview, the researchers arranged an extra screening event for the most promising candidates. They were invited to a hands-on interview where there was offered a simulation of realistic work situation setting and tasks, which the future employee would encounter in the organization. In order to understand the candidates' suitability more profoundly, design methods were applied to support communication and create scenery or a setting of a rather realistic working situation to find the most suitable candidates.

The recruiting prototype was applied into two distinct recruiting events. In the first stage three manager candidates were tested separately and then two full teams were tested one team at a time.

RECRUITING WORKSHOP 1.0 FOR DIRECTOR CANDIDATES

The recruiting workshops for the director candidates were arranged as sessions where one candidate was present at a time and three researchers acted as the future team. The recruiting workshop was designed to test candidates' leading practices, skills and way of thinking. In the workshop there were four exercises, which the candidates performed either individually or with the help of three researchers who acted as his future team, meanwhile one of the researchers facilitated the session.

During the director recruiting workshops only the three most promising candidates were tested to learn if they had the skills and characteristics that were thought to be important to run the specific consultancy unit and if the values of the candidates met the values of the organization.

The first recruiting workshop lasted one and a half hours consisting of three parts of strictly framed assignments and tight time frames. In all the parts pictures, figures, other visual material and cardboard miniatures were used as communication tools. During all the tests a facilitator, three researchers (acting as team members) and two observers were present, who all evaluated the performance of the candidate.

The leading thought behind the workshop structure was the idea that in the first two parts the candidate presented himself and in the latter two parts the researchers observed if his words applied in reality. The characteristics for the first parts of the workshop were of conversational and descriptive nature and latter parts were more action-based. In the following we will explain the workshop structure and the materials in more detail.

STRUCTURE OF THE RECRUITING WORKSHOP

In the first two exercises the candidates described their personality, skills and motivations. The last two exercises were task simulating and more action-liked.

1. Warming up, quick self-presentation with the help of images used as metaphors Sub-subsection heads

The applicants were instructed to choose the images, among tens of pictures, that best described his character and skills and attach them into a paper (Figure 1). Additionally to this they were supposed to choose a word from a list that would best describe their performance in a group situation. In the end they were asked to present themselves with the help of the chosen photos.



Figure 1. The setting for self-presentation task



Figure 2. A game-like value model as a discussion and decision-making tool

2.1 Team leading: Defining motivators for a team in a group with a tailor-made game board

Part two included team-work and solo performing. In the team task the candidate was instructed to lead a team and find common values for the team. The group was given a game-like 3D board and figures with value related words to choose from. The figures included also images in addition to words to help the team in communicating (Figures 2-3).



Figure 4. A miniature model of the future office layout worked as a tool to communicate and concretize intangible idea

2.2. The next task was about applying the defined motivators in practice

This task included solo performing based on the earlier task. The applicant was instructed to apply the values defined in the previous task into a miniature of the real working space of the future unit by making changes to the layout by building and drawing. (Figure 4.) They were also asked to form their own future team by choosing suitable team members among given figures and defining their roles and physical locations in the working space. To get maximum amount of information the candidates were encouraged to speak out their thoughts to reason every action while performing the given tasks.

3. Action: Leading a planning meeting

In the last round the director candidate was again supposed to lead a team-work situation that was based on realistic future challenges (Figure 5). They were instructed to lead a planning meeting about organizing an event related to contemporary issue within a tight timeframe. The team was supposed to ideate, plan and come up with a result, working on a realistic work case – in this task the candidates had an opportunity to show visionary and leading skills in practice. The other team members had predefined roles (which were played by the researchers); an active and positive one, a passive one and a critical one.



Figure 5. The group task environment simulated a basic meeting situation

RECRUITING WORKSHOP 2.0 FOR EMPLOYEE CANDIDATES

After choosing a director for the new consultancy unit, another version of recruiting workshop was arranged to find the most suitable employees who would form a dynamic group with a variety of skills and know-how. Two identical recruiting workshops were arranged to find complementary team members. Each session had four candidates each applying for a different role of all the four employee profiles that would form the complete future team. This resulted that there was no straight competition among the applicants in a workshop situation. During the two recruiting workshops eight most promising candidates were tested after traditional written application and interviewing rounds.

In addition to the actual team recruiting workshop the candidates were also given an individual task in advance related to their possible future role. They were asked to present it to the researchers separately at the group sessions. The actual employee recruiting workshop was arranged similarly to the director recruiting event. The only difference was that the group of applicants was performing the tasks together and the second part of the test was lacking the individual task of team leading. The final planning task was led by the already recruited director of the new consultancy unit, so that he could influence the composition of his future team.

During all the tasks the three researchers (acting as team members) and two observers all evaluated the performance of the candidates. The researchers had defined a criterion for the evaluation to point out what exactly was to be observed and measured e.g. leading manners and skills, level of ideas and enthusiasm. After each recruiting workshop all the evaluators filled in evaluation forms individually. Then the suitability of the candidate was evaluated in mutual discussions until everyone of the evaluation group agreed on the candidate's suitability to the specific position.

A director and two employees were hired to run the new consultancy unit as a result of all the five recruiting workshops. Two more employees were recruited traditionally after the research case since the arranged employee recruiting workshops did not result in finding all four complementing profiles to form a full team.

MAIN FINDINGS

CRITERIA OF MEASURING

A simple metrics of desired qualities and skills was defined to support evaluation of observers while monitoring candidates during the workshops. The predefined measuring scale was based only on facts such as if the tasks were performed efficiently within time limits etc. As a negative surprise the metrics proved to be superficial indicators and contradictory to observers' subjective evaluation. When evaluating a candidate who performed excellently according to the metrics, the intuitive subjective evaluation may not support it at all. Surprisingly the defined evaluation criteria did not leave any room e.g. for evaluating complex values of candidates' that are challenging to describe and define in a measurable scale. No matter how the applicant's performance was evaluated from subjective evaluation point of view, the superficiality of evaluation criteria confused observers' evaluation process.

Therefore we suggest that the recruiting context, that often includes subjective decision-making, could consider designerly approaches that, rather than measuring particular attributes, tries to grasp a more holistic view.

CHALLENGE OF EVALUATING LONG-TERM PERFORMANCE

A potential weakness of our recruiting workshop method might be that it reveals only short term motivation and commitment. There is no guarantee

that the best performing applicants of the recruiting workshop are the most suitable employees in long term. The testing situation and its tight time frame and specified tasks and framework might also set competitive circumstances which might influence on the motivation and behavior of the candidates. Nevertheless, in addition to interviewing observing applicant's working performance in a real working content provides more information about the applicant than a one-dimensional traditional oral interview.

I SAY I DO – OR DO I?

Traditional job interviews are often arranged in the same way and therefore candidates know how to behave and what type of performance is expected from them. However, according to our case study through the prototyping-driven, hands-on recruiting experiments that we have described earlier we were also able to observe the candidate's working performance, character and their performance as being part of a team.

The first part of the recruiting workshop revealed how a person describes himself or what is the "ideal himself". As complementation, the latter part revealed if the candidate could transform his values into practice and if his self-description of character and skills correlated with his performance. E.g. several candidates described themselves as creative, flexible or innovative but in practice their performance during accomplishing the workshop tasks did not support their argument.

THE STRENGTHS

The main strength of the recruiting workshop was the idea of enabling observing a candidate in the future work related action. The evaluators thus have more information to judge the suitability of the candidate rather holistically. In an ideal scenario the recruiting workshop revealed the coherency of skills, characteristics and manners of self-descriptions related to these qualities in practice. On the other hand the future employee candidate might learn about the organization and its culture as well during the recruiting event.

These first experiments suggest that the recruiting methods presented in this paper suite quite well for situations, where an already existing team will be reinforced with a new employee, while they provide a setting for testing group dynamics. If the existing team is taking part in a recruiting workshop, all the team members can prove if the new employee candidate suits the existing team or not. When observing a group of candidates performing the given tasks together it was obvious to notice if the group dynamic worked well or not and what exactly was the input of each applicant. This is in line with Whole Foods Market case mentioned earlier. Related to this idea the Whole Foods Market has developed a quite unique recruiting process based on the team members' interviews, where existing employees have an opportunity to test the candidate and his suitability for becoming a new team member (Hamel 2007; Whole Foods Market 2011).

VISUAL TOOLS AS COMMUNICATION ENHANCERS

Visual tools were tailor-made for the recruiting workshops to support communication during the exercises. Within the tight time frames, visual material enhanced communication and interaction. Tangible objects and figures concretized intangibles and resulted in fluent interaction. Miniatures in turn worked as tools e.g. for director candidates to concretize their managerial thoughts – how were the motivators (defined during the second task) to be concretized in a miniature model of the actual space of the future organization.

CONCLUSIONS

Taking a stance on the one-dimensionality of the traditional recruiting interview, we argue, based on the case study, that by enhancing practical working performance in recruiting process applicants' motivations, interests, practical skills and suitability can be revealed in new ways. Practical hands-on recruiting workshop also formulates a holistic picture and character of the vacancy for the applicants. In a larger scale, based on the experiment, we suggest that design methods as means and prototyping-driven attitude when challenging, developing or upgrading management processes and practices (recruiting process as a study case), can lead into a

fresh understanding when performing organizational practices and executing important organizational decisions.

Acknowledging other innovative recruiting practices (see Carbonara 1996; Whole Foods Markets 2011) done by the few pioneers, the aim of the case study was not to establish a universal approach to every organizational challenge. Instead we see "designerly way" of doing things as a potential approach to develop organizational practices, which are rooted deeply in organizational cultures. Design thinking as a framework can provide to managers and organizational developers a different kind of point of view to do the development work. Here, the process started with the explorative mindset including willingness to explore new possibilities. Visualizations and rapid prototyping are potential tools to design better solutions for given problem or challenge. However, the study case was our first implementation of the recruiting workshop concept in re-designing recruiting practices. Further research, development and prototyping are needed before these practices can be established in organizations**.**

FUTURE WORK AND ITS CHALLENGES

The first prototypes of the recruiting workshops resulted as promising implementations of upgraded recruiting practices, revealing novel perspectives of the potential future employees than a traditional interview. The promising results encouraged us to explore further the possibilities of the concept. Therefore an elaborated prototype will be applied and tested in another recruiting context to further develop the concept.

The possibility of defining the metrics to evaluate non-articulative observations by utilizing emphatic design methods should be considered to be researched and developed further. This would then offer a vocabulary when judging, analyzing and communicating intuitive non-articulative observations of the candidates' performances. Other important dimensions of the recruiting workshop to be challenged are its suitability to manifold organization types and contexts as well as minimizing the organizing efforts to increase its efficiency.

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